



EWICHER YEEGER/HOLLERSEGE 10. NEWWELING, 2018

ROBERT LUSCH (MIT DENKI ZUM BRIAN WEIS)
REV-D 1

Honoring: Der Ewich Yeeger (Holler), der Schlumm

Intonation of the Runes

Each rune intoned thrice: Dunner, Eiwe, Geil, Loch

Die Heiliching - The Hallowing

*Schtaab, heilich daer Aldaar un die Schtell
Beschitz uns mit der Graft vun de Ziewe,
Bei Wudan un Frigg fer der Gemeeschaft zu baue
Bei Ziu un Zisa fer die Gerechdicheet un der Fruchsfriede zu erhalde
Bei Frey un Freya fer die Wohldaat zu schneide un sammle
Bei Dunner un Siwwa fer es Volk vollzumechtiche.
Bei Fraa Holle, Weisskeppiche Fraa, un Ewiche Yeeger un fer es Volk
zu erneire
Wie schmittet der Hammer die Sichel,
So die Sichel der Hammer fiedert.
'S iss es Lewesraad, zu saehe un zu schneide
Schtaab, heilich daer Aldaar un die Schtell*

Heel!

Heel!

Heel!

Unser Zweck - Our Purpose

Heit sammle mir uns do, fer der Holler un der Ewicher Yeeger, der Retter vun de Siedlinge, zu ehre.

Heel zu de Ziewe!

Heel zu de Wichde!

Heel zum Land!

Heel zu der Gmeeschaft!

Der Aaruf - The Invocation

Invocations to Ewicher Yeeger / Holler and to the Schlumm will be made both in Deutsch and in English.

Es Opfer un Die Eed - The Offering and the Oaths

*Losst uns enniche Opfer uff der Aldaar adder in 's Feier yetz schtelle
Un wann ennichebber hot en Eed zu bschweere, kumm yetz voraa.*

*If anyone has any offerings, please place them onto the altar, or, later, into the fire.
If anyone has any oaths to take, come forward now.*

Schpaatschtich – Groundbreaking

Breaking the ground to plant the trees as part of Cherie's memorial site.

Die Heiliching vun de Opfer - The Hallowing of the Offerings

Die Ausdeeling - The Distribution

Der Sege - The Blessing

When pouring the libations, all say (choose either language):

*Vun de Ziewe zu der Erd zu uns
Vun uns zu der Erd zu de Gedder*

*From the gods to the Earth to us
From us to the Earth to the gods*

*'N Gschenk fer 'n Gschenk
Heele!*

*A gift for a gift.
Hail!*

Zum Schluss - In Closing

Zu de Wichde - To the Wights

DISCUSSION TOPICS

Read the myth “Ewicher Yeeger,” pp. 28-41 in “The First Book of Urglaawe Myths.”

EWICHER YEEGER; DER EWICH YEEGER; THE ETERNAL HUNTER

Der Ewich Yeeger (known by numerous spellings) is a spirit known in English as the Eternal Hunter. He is credited with rescuing the early Deitsch settlements on the south side of the Blue Mountain. A crop failure had threatened to starve the settlements over the winter. That crop failure also resulted in deer and rabbits migrating to the south to find food. Ewicher Yeeger saved the folk by driving the game over the ridge towards the villages.

The harsh Colonial-era history of the area we know as the Allemaengel indicates that the rescued settlements were in this area. Eugene Stine describes this area (the name of which translates to "all deficiencies") in a 1940s Deitsch newspaper article as long being associated with sorcery and also with other issues that would lead to crop failures. The location of the Allemaengel is near present-day Lynnport, PA.

Some variations of the story say that He was a human who turned into this air spirit. Other variants, including the one I heard growing up from my family along the ridge of the Blue Mountain, state that He is a spirit, and entity, or a deity. Urglaawe views Him in the deity role, particularly given the care taken to ensure the settlements' survival.

His story runs all along the ridge, and it also appears in other nearby areas, including Oley Furnace, Yellow Mountain, South Mountain, and Neversink Mountain.

I have heard Him four times in my life, and it is an indescribable sound. Some say they believe the noise of His pack of hounds is the result of flocks of Canadian geese. Others say that it is a result of warm air bouncing off of the ridge when the air in the valleys is cold. However, the sound comes at you from all directions (like sensaround), and in flashes, sort of like the audio version of a strobe light. It is momentarily disorienting, and it is loud and intense. He is generally seen as harsh yet helpful, particularly given the fact that He rescued the settlements. However, He is also viewed as a large entity, who is running errands that defy our comprehension, so it would be easy for Him to roll over someone without Him even realizing he had done it.

The attached picture is from a painting entitled “The Eternal Hunter,” which was painted by J. Allen Pawling. It appears in print in “Echoes of Scholla – Illustrated: Choice Bits of Berks County History and Lore” by Arthur D. Graeff and George M. Meiser, IX, Kutztown: Berksiana Foundation, 1976.

Folks sometimes attempt to make a connection between Ewicher Yeeger and Wudan via the Wild Hunt. However, Ewicher Yeeger is always on the hunt, and there is a definite Vanic feel to His energy. Other folks associate him with Herne the Hunter, and I can see how they make the connection. My personal viewpoint is that He is a very old, god of the Wane and is likely the same as Holler. A similar god seems to be known in Switzerland, and it is plausible that His story came with the Deitsch settlers who came from there. Either way, I have met Him. :)

Variations of the story may also be found in published works. Here are just a few of them:

Adams, Charles J. III. *Ghost Stories of Berks County*. Shillington, PA: Mifflin Publications, 1982.

Adams, Charles J. III. *Coal Country Ghosts: Legends and Lore – Schuylkill and Carbon Counties, Pennsylvania*. Wyomissing, PA: Exeter House, 2004.

Polley, Jane, ed. “Homely and Earthy Talk: Pennsylvanians from Germany.” *American Folklore and Legend*, pp. 27-29. Pleasantville, NY: Reader’s Digest, 1978.

Wentz, Richard E. *Pennsylvania Dutch Folk Spirituality*. New York: Paulist Press, 1993.



SCRAPPLE

Although scrapple is likely older than the Colonies, its spread throughout the Deitsch region as a staple food is often association in the mountains with Ewicher Yeeger. The game that he is said to have driven over the ridge includes rabbit, which is the original meat of scrapple. In fact, scrapple is called “Pannhaas” (“pan-rabbit”) in Deitsch. Thus, scrapple, along with cloth and hay, is an appropriate offering to Ewicher Yeeger.

HOLLER

The oral lore we have for Holler is scant. What we know from Hexerei lore is that He is a master hunter and a god of death and of transformation. A remnant of a tale indicates that He destroys tender plants after Allelieweziel to keep the Frost Giants from taking their energies. It is also likely that He is Holle's consort.

EWICHER YEEGER = HOLLER?

Although it remains unproven, it has become increasingly accepted within the Urglaawe and Hexerei communities that Ewicher Yeeger and Holler are one and the same. Honoring Holler by name in the Hollersege will be a feature of Saturday's event.

DIE VERSCHIMPFING GEEICH DER REIFKEENICH - RAILING AGAINST KING FROST

The Frost Giants are aware of Holle's departure on the Wild Hunt, and they begin their advancement toward the Hatzholz (Midgard/Mannheim: where we live) from the Northern Leaves. In some versions of the King Frost tale, the Giants' army includes some familiar names: Dreizehdax, Vatzehvedder, and Fuffzehfux. These are the Giants who come in May in an attempt to destroy the expanding fertility of the land. Their visit at this time of year prepares the way for the arrival of King Frost, who brings the killing frost to the land.

Regarding King Frost, we will also engage in an old mountain Hexerei tradition of railing against him and his armies. While the Giants ultimately take the land in Holle's absence, the railing weakens their ranks and allows more time for Holler to direct their souls to the Wild Hunt.

How this is done:

Winter is natural and necessary for this region. Many seeds need extended time in frozen temperatures, etc. Thus, the best way to frame this entire effort is to focus on winter's grasp over us as individuals. Each of us can assert our authority over ourselves not to become sullen from the heavy snows or the cabin fever. Thus, we are railing against our own reactions to winter, too.

The tool we use is a staff (Schtaab) or, not so ironically, a rail (Riggel). Defensive words are spoken into the end of the staff that will start out in the Abscheechendi (shooing/removing/banishing hand).

Admittedly, curses against the destructive forces have also been spoken historically. These words would be spoken into the Aawendendi (application hand).

What is said: The contents are pretty much up to the individual. This is a form of sympathetic magic, and there are chants or incantations that can be uttered. There are, however, Verbots in place, so I will not write them; a future translation without Verbots is a possibility within the Urglaawe guilds. This is not a matter of withholding as much as it is respect for the practice.

One thing, though, that can be said into both ends of the staff liberally is, "Zing!" This is likely a contraction of "zieh dei(n) Gift" ("move thy poison"). It is said like "TSEENG."

After the words are spoken into the staff, the staff is then lifted above the head and then wielded, shaken, and/or swung in the dominant hand ("more [insert noun] than you can shake a stick at") in a sympathetic striking of the target of the rail. Words may also be uttered during this process. When one feels he or she has sufficiently made a statement, the rail is lowered. It can later be stood in a doorway or hung on a wall for at least three, six, or nine nights... after nine nights, it may be removed at any time.

We are keeping this defensive. The act of cursing is very dangerous as the energies it creates can harm the self and witnesses. There may be times when cursing is necessary against truly destructive forces, but the coming of winter in the era of modern conveniences is not worth a stain on our Wurt. By framing this as a struggle against ourselves, we have no need to curse and can instead focus on defending ourselves against our own reactions.

YODELING

Yodeling has a long history among the Deutsch and an even longer history among the Germanic people. There is a spirituality about yodeling that we are going to begin to incorporate into our runic intonations and into other ceremonial practices, too.

Ewicher Yeeger: Why Honor Death?

The night of November 10 begins final day of the Urglaawe observance of Allelieweziel. Now we honor Holler, who is also known as Ewicher Yeeger. His association with death is reflected in the translation of His byname into English: the Eternal Hunter. Indeed, He is seen by many as Death personified, and imagery and versions of folk tales over the centuries have presented Him as a bringer of disruption, disease, destruction, and, well, death. So, this begs the question: Why honor Him?

There are many possible answers to this question. Ironically, the most significant tale about Holler shows a merciful side to Him that is not typically associated with death. While death appeared imminent to the settlers of Lynn Township, the fact that they recognized the error of their ways and gave up offerings caused Holler to save the colony. Driving game over the Blobarrick ridge provided the settlers with food to survive through the winter months.

While this story is one version of the best-known tale of Ewicher Yeeger, there are bits of knowledge and remnants of other tales that reflect a complex character to this god. One of the more curious remnants reflects the push and pull among the various forces in existence as viewed within our physical world. After Holle's departure and the burning of the Butzemanner, King Frost's armies are on the move into our realm. The Frost Giants seize the spirits of the plants and animals (and humans, for that matter?) that they kill, thereby removing them from the cycle of life, death, and rebirth. In this tale remnant, Holler brings death and/or dormancy to the weaker plants and animals. Those who die are released to the Wild Hunt, which ensures their continuity in the cycle of life, death, and rebirth. The Frost Giants pass by the dormant spirits, who sleep safely until Spring under the care of an entity named Schlumm.

In this case, we see Holler playing a role in tandem with Holle. He aids in the ongoing cycle of life even while bringing death. This reinforces the idea that death is a part of life and also of rebirth.

Another tidbit is a little more confusing because it conflates Ewicher Yeeger with aspects of Krampus. In this instance, Ewicher Yeeger is a punisher and a wild, primal beast. This tidbit is an outlier from most understandings of Ewicher Yeeger, but it is not the only one. Other versions reflect lore related to the Wild Hunt found in other Germanic lands. Some say Ewicher Yeeger is actually a cursed nobleman (much like Count Hackelberg in Germany) who is doomed to hunt as payback for his misdeeds in life.

These stories are worth mentioning, though, because they reflect the convolution of tales over many centuries and across many lands, including the Deitsch lands in Pennsylvania. However, the most intact story from the Deitsch cultural context places Ewicher Yeeger as an entity (or in the Urglaawe context, a god) strongly associated with death yet not to be pigeonholed.

The understanding conveyed to me about Ewicher Yeeger throughout my lifetime has been one of an entity who is much larger than our understanding. He has His own agenda and purposes for actions that we cannot always fathom. In Braucherei, He is appealed to for brute strength, terminations, and transformations.

The transformation aspect plays a major role in our understanding of death. Death is scary. Death is unwanted. Yet Death comes to all of us at some point. One theme of Allelieweziel is that we live in a society that, on the one hand, likes to pretend that death does not exist. Yet, on the other hand, we are obsessed with it. We depict it so cavalierly in movies and on television, yet we don't want to plan for the end of the lives of our loved ones or of ourselves.

Most Urglaawer believe in some form of rebirth. The most common belief is that at least one part of the soul is reborn into a new, unique construct, thus giving us opportunities to grow and to expand our consciousness from lifetime to lifetime. We hope that, at the end of this cosmic cycle, we will be where the deities were at the beginning of it. Our corporeal forms have limits to our lifetimes, but each experience in this physical realm affords us the opportunity to increase the human life wave.

Thus, death is not to be feared per se; instead, it is part of the continuity of life and the evolution of existence. While we are to embrace our lives and to make the most of them, the eventuality of death is something with which we all must reconcile ourselves.

Thus, we take a moment at this time of Ewicher Yeeger to understand our mortality, to consider how to make the most of the current life we have, and to ponder the prospects for a better future for humanity. We honor the god who helps us to prepare for and to confront the reality of death even while celebrating the life we have.

Thus, at this time of the observance of Ewicher Yeeger, let us hail Holler.

EWICHER YEEGER AS RIVER GOD

A couple of years ago, I was driving up to the Urglaawe cemetery on back roads. It was a nice day to drive after several days of heavy rain. I noticed that the Hollenbach (one Deutsch name for Jordan Creek in Lehigh County, PA) was flowing particularly strongly (and it normally is pretty fast to begin with), so I pulled onto a side road, got out of my truck, and walked onto a bridge that looks over the creek.

While I was standing there, an old man walked up from the side road carrying fishing gear. He greeted me, and we struck up a conversation. Through the course of the chat, I mentioned the Urglaawe Folklore Research Project, which interested him immensely. This part of Lehigh County is Bloarrick (Blue Mountain) country and is thus Ewicher Yeeger's stomping grounds.

I asked him if he knew any folk stories from the region, and he replied that he did. When I mentioned Ewicher Yeeger, his face lit up, and he said that he knew a few stories. One that he told was very similar to the Ewicher Yeeger story of Allemaengel, but then he told me an anecdote that I found interesting.

He said that when he was a boy, his brother, some friends, and he used to fish in the Hollenbach, and there was an old man, whose name he could not recollect, who used to fish in the creek as well. He said the old man was very mysterious and he was not sure of much about him other than that he was from Werleseck (Werleys Corner) and that people considered him to be a hermit. The old man would talk to the boys and would tell them stories about the area (some of which he related to me).

He said that what he recalled vividly was that he thought some of the man's actions were peculiar. He would throw beans, corn, worms, flowers or plants, cheese, or other items into the creek before and/or after he fished, whether he caught something or not. He said that when the old man would catch a fish, he would utter a word of thanks to the Eternal Hunter for giving him a meal that night. He would then throw some food into the creek for the fish.

When I remarked on only having heard of Ewicher Yeeger in the context of the hunt, he replied, "Fishing is a bit like hunting, gell?"

He then remarked that he thinks of the mysterious old man occasionally when he is fishing or when he walks past the area where the old man used to fish. We continued to talk as we walked along the creek so he could show me where the man used to fish, and he admitted that he on occasion whispers a thanks to Ewicher Yeeger when he catches a fish or has a successful hunt.

The description given to me about the mysterious man indicates that he was a Braucher or a Hex and that the man relating this story to me was witnessing the hermit's rituals. The man with whom I was speaking was born "during the time that the people were depressed" so he is likely at least in his 80s, and he said the hermit was very old when he was about age 11-15 or 16. This would put the hermit as being born sometime, perhaps during the 1850s-1870s.

The man said he would ask his brother if he remembered any other stories that the old man or anyone else told when they were boys and he'd contact me if he learned anything.

DER SCHLUMM: GOD OR GIANT OF SLUMBER?

Among some of the more difficult references I have come across in my research has been the enigmatic figure called “der Schlumm” in Deutsch. He is often referred to as “the Schlumm” in English, rather than just “Schlumm.” References are scant, and it has been impossible for me to determine whether the Schlumm is considered to be a Zieb (God) or a Ries (Giant), but there is an indication from one source that Schlumm and Holler are brothers, which would make Schlumm a deity of the Wane.

Most references place him into a seemingly important role of day and night cycles, including cosmic slumber. He is definitely liminal and is associated with sleep states and altered states. His effect can protect people or beings, or it can harm them. As mentioned above, dormant plants are under his care until they awaken and are cared for by the god Luul.

While I am still slowly working on the organization of the scant and scattered information I have on Schlumm, we can begin to hail him in the context of the regeneration he gives us each night.